

Week 8: Naturalism

BIG IDEA

Naturalism, the dominant worldview of Western culture, says only what the five senses can detect constitutes reality, and meaning must come through science. But it cannot answer how or why, or ground justice, love, and morality; as Ecclesiastes shows, without God putting meaning in life, everything is meaningless.

KEY POINTS FROM THE LEADER VIDEO

- Naturalism teaches that only what we can taste, touch, smell, see, and feel constitutes reality, and students meet it daily, especially in school science classes.
- Naturalism says any meaning in life must be found through science, but science only reaches the natural world; the lesson's goal is seeing it cannot work.
- Closely tied to atheism, naturalism cannot explain the universe's how or why; the why question can be asked over and over without an answer.
- Justice, love, and morality are not tangible things the senses can grab, yet some morals are universal across all cultures, demanding a deeper explanation.
- Ecclesiastes opens 'meaningless, meaningless, utterly meaningless': Solomon's point is that without God putting meaning in life, all our labor is meaningless.
- Believing in naturalism while caring for orphans, widows, or clean water is inconsistent; that sense of justice points beyond nature to a Creator God.

SCRIPTURE

Ecclesiastes 1:2-4

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. Where does naturalism show up in your school and classes, beyond just evolutionary science?
2. If only the natural world exists, where would justice, love, and morality come from?
3. Why do people without belief in God still care about clean water or helping others? What does that inclination suggest?
4. From a naturalistic worldview, what would give your work or efforts any meaning? Does that answer satisfy you?

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